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IS 8201 – English for the Professional World

Faculty of Engineering
University of Ruhuna





Lesson 2:

Discourse, Idiomatic
Language &
Discourse Markers



Content of the lesson:

1. What is discourse?
2. What are discourse markers?
3. Idiomatic language in professional contexts

1. What is discourse?

Discourse is spoken or written communication between people, especially serious discussion of a particular subject”.

- *Collins Dictionary*



2. What are discourse markers?

- Discourse markers are words or expressions that link, manage and help to organise sentences.
- They connect what is written or said with something else.
- They make no change to the meaning.
- They are also often called linking words and, sometimes, *fillers*.
- ▶▶ They are important to make your speech or text flow and to avoid a series of short unconnected statements.

- Discourse markers can be placed in any part of a sentence, including the beginning.
- We use different types of *discourse markers* for different types of links; **informal markers** for speech and **formal markers** for formal writing, such as essays and reports.
- Discourse markers are important for fluency in English at an advanced level.
- They are important elements of speech and writing for living and working in English-speaking countries.

- Discourse markers generally do not change the intrinsic meaning of a sentence, although sometimes they are important for clarity and logical linking of ideas.

- For example, you could say:

“John has broken his leg. He attends his team’s football matches every week.”

- These sentences are grammatically and factually correct, but they don’t really convey the full message. Instead, you could say:



“Despite the fact that John has broken his leg, he still attends his team’s football matches every week.”

By adding these discourse markers, you are emphasizing John’s dedication to supporting his team despite his misfortune - without having

Informal discourse markers

- When speaking or informal writing, such as emails or texts to friends, the following discourse markers are often used.
- **Anyway** – marks a shift away from a topic. *It's sold out, anyway, I didn't want to go.*
- **Actually** – indicates that what you are saying is a surprise to you or is the opposite of what might be imagined or introduces the opposite response to what someone wants or expects. *I thought I didn't like dance shows but actually, I quite enjoyed it. Actually, I'd prefer it if you didn't smoke in here.*
- **As I was saying / As I said** – continuing a theme after a change of subject. *As I was saying before I was interrupted, I'd like to go to the cinema. As I said last week, I don't enjoy opera.*
- **Absolutely** – used as a stronger way of saying yes. *A. Would you like a holiday in Thailand? B. Absolutely, when do we go?*
- **Exactly** – used to emphasize what you mean. *What exactly are you talking about? Exactly, that's what I meant.*

- **Okay** or **OK** – understood or agreed. *Okay, I get it.*
- **Well** – used to indicate an emotion including annoyance, anger, surprise, disappointment and relief. *Well, that's not what I wanted to hear. Well, I didn't expect that* ←
- **Fine** – used informally to indicate that something is not good. *That's another fine mess you've got me into. A. How are you since your wife left you? B, Fine, what do you think*
- **Mind (you)** – used to highlight or stress something you said to avoid misunderstanding. *He couldn't help me, mind you, I know he's busy so it's not his fault.* Or to introduce something else that needs to be considered. *My kids never listen to me. Mind you, I didn't either at their age so I guess it's normal.*
- **You know** – indicates that what you're saying is known by the listener or to check they understand with a question mark. Also used as a filler while you're thinking of what to say next. *Studying economics is hard, you know.*

- **I mean** – introduces a statement to justify what you've said. *It was a tough driving test, I mean I took my test in the rush hour in the rain.*
- **For a start** – introduces the first item of a logical sequence or the most important item of other possibilities. *The driving test in Spain is difficult, for a start it's all in Spanish.*
- **What's more** – introduces a new fact or argument and implies that this new fact or argument is more important than the one just given. Used without contraction for formal speech and writing. *The stock market fell in 2008 and what's more, our pension fund was tied up in stocks.*
- **On top of that** – used to indicate something unpleasant in addition to what you've just said. *I lost my job and on top of that, I was fined for speeding.*
- **To tell you the truth** – indicates that what you're saying is honest and open. *To tell you the truth, I was more than a little worried. Truth be told, I'm concerned about the project*
- **To be honest** – explains that you are being truthful about what you're saying, usually with an understanding that the person you're talking to will be disappointed. *To be honest, I don't think your offer is sufficient.*
- **Sort of / kind of** – used to describe that something is partly true but it's not the entire explanation. Or that something is difficult to explain entirely. *Your answer is sort of correct but there's a bit more to it than that. My new car is a kind of blue-green colour. Not sure what colour you'd call it.*

Formal and written discourse markers

- Discourse markers for more formal writing situations organise your text logically.
- They are typical when writing formal letters or when writing essays or reports, especially at work.
- They will also be used in formal speaking situations, such as presentations or speeches.



Comparing and contrasting



- When you want to talk about how two things are different, or look at alternatives, you might use these words and phrases:
 - ✓ Whereas
 - ✓ On the contrary
 - ✓ Nevertheless
 - ✓ Even though
 - ✓ Instead of

Similarities



- To talk about two things that are almost the same, and highlight similarities, transition words such as these will help:
 - ✓ Similarly
 - ✓ Likewise
 - ✓ Analagous to
 - ✓ In a similar fashion
 - ✓ Just as
 - ✓ Equally
 - ✓ In the same way

Addition

- These expressions are used when you need to add to what you have already said:
 - ✓ As well (as)
 - ✓ Additionally
 - ✓ Furthermore
 - ✓ What's more
 - ✓ On top of this
 - ✓ Besides





Giving examples

- If you need to illustrate a point or give an example of what you mean, these phrases can help:
 - ✓ For example
 - ✓ For instance
 - ✓ Such as
 - ✓ As we can see from
 - ✓ As shown by
 - ✓ In particular
 - ✓ Especially

Cause and effect / reason



- When talking about one thing that caused or impacted another thing, you'll need some of these:
 - ✓ Because
 - ✓ As a result of
 - ✓ Thanks to
 - ✓ This has the effect of
 - ✓ Consequently
 - ✓ Since
 - ✓ In that case
 - ✓ Otherwise

Indicating time order

- These words and phrases are helpful for giving time order or structure to a sequence of events or points:
 - ✓ To begin with
 - ✓ First of all
 - ✓ Secondly
 - ✓ Then
 - ✓ After this
 - ✓ Finally
 - ✓ In the end
 - ✓ Last of all





Clarification

- If you need to explain something in a different way or clarify a point, you can use phrases like this:
 - ✓ What I mean is
 - ✓ Look at it this way
 - ✓ In other words
 - ✓ If I'm not mistaken
 - ✓ To be clear
 - ✓ This is to say that
 - ✓ For the avoidance of doubt



Emphasis

- Sometimes you need to emphasize a particular point when speaking or writing. In these cases, the following emphasis discourse markers are useful:
 - ✓ As a matter of fact
 - ✓ Indeed
 - ✓ Actually
 - ✓ I must admit
 - ✓ To be honest
 - ✓ To tell you the truth
 - ✓ To say the least

Conclusion



- And finally, it can be helpful to use these words and phrases to indicate the conclusion of what we are saying:
 - ✓ In conclusion
 - ✓ This brings us to the conclusion that
 - ✓ What this all means is
 - ✓ To wrap up
 - ✓ In summary
 - ✓ I'll end by saying that

Task

Choose words from the box to fill in the spaces in the exercise below.

moreover

firstly

on the other hand

whereas

at least

then

however

actually

besides

though

1. I had a terrible day at work and lost my umbrella too. I spoke to that nice guy who works in the coffee shop at last!
2. Television turns people into lazy couch potatoes., there are some educational programmes on.
3., I would like to welcome you all to the conference today.
4. the film was a little boring, we still had a nice evening out.

5. I've always known Caroline as a mean person., she lent me \$10 yesterday without having to ask twice!
6. I got up at 9 o'clock yesterday and had a cold shower., I had breakfast and left for work.
7. My brother works in a large office I work on my own at home.
8. Why don't you think I would want to go out tonight?, I would be delighted to get out of the house.
9. You should go to university as it gives you a chance to meet so many new people.
....., it gives you the chance to get important qualifications and get a better job.
10. I don't want to go to the football game. Football bores me and I don't want to pay \$40 for a ticket., look at the weather! All that rain!

Answers

1. I had a terrible day at work and lost my umbrella too. **AT LEAST** I spoke to that nice guy who works in the coffee shop at last!
2. Television turns people into lazy couch potatoes. **ON THE OTHER HAND**, there are some educational programmes on.
3. **FIRSTLY**, I would like to welcome you all to the conference today.
4. **THOUGH** the film was a little boring, we still had a nice evening out.
5. I've always known Caroline as a mean person. **HOWEVER**, she lent me \$10 yesterday without having to ask twice!
6. I got up at 9 o'clock yesterday and had a cold shower. **THEN**, I had breakfast and left for work.
7. My brother works in a large office **WHEREAS** I work on my own at home.
8. Why don't you think I would want to go out tonight? **ACTUALLY**, I would be delighted to get out of the house.
9. You should go to university as it gives you a chance to meet so many new people. **MOREOVER**, it gives you the chance to get important qualifications and get a better job.
10. I don't want to go to the football game. Football bores me and I don't want to pay \$40 for a ticket. **BESIDES**, look at the weather! All that rain!

Task

Create sentences for the pictures below by using discourse markers.

Accordingly

Even so

On the whole

Nevertheless

By and large

On the contrary

Having said that

Conversely

In addition to

Incidentally

Likewise

Example:

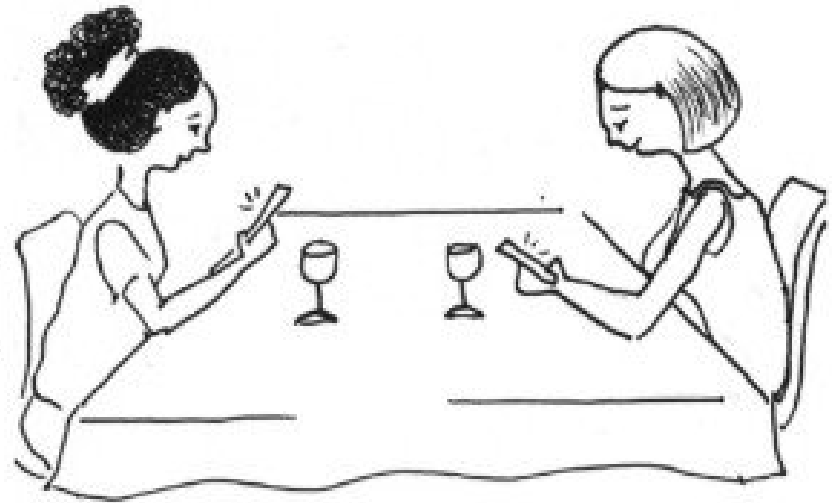
“Many parents feel they can ensure high-quality education for their children by paying for it. **Conversely**, I’d say it has little to do with money, and more to do with each teacher’s skill and dedication.



Many parents feel they can ensure high-quality education for their children by paying for it.



Being a YouTuber or a streamer is not believed to be a very stable profession.



Technology is often seen as posing a threat to our communication skills.



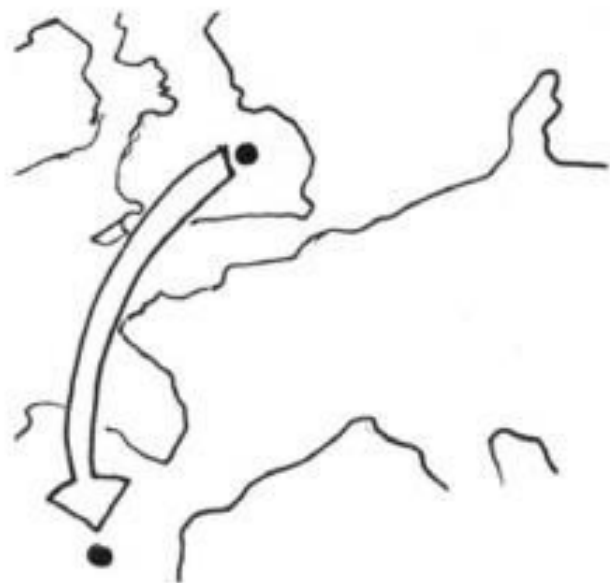
Many people argue that buying local products supports local communities.



Consumers are becoming increasingly aware of how their choices impact the environment.



Many parents send their children to mixed schools to socialise with male and female peers.



Settling down in a foreign country is not always as idyllic as it first appears.



3. Idiomatic language in professional contexts



Why do we use idioms?

1. Implied Communication: Idioms convey messages in a way that improves readers' interest and arouses their senses. For instance, when someone says “spill the beans,” they're not literally talking about pouring out a can of beans; they mean revealing a secret.

2. Simplicity: Idioms simplify complex ideas. They encapsulate broader meanings in a concise manner. For example, “seeing the forest for the trees” describes someone who focuses too much on details and misses the bigger picture.



3. Enriching Speech: Using idioms enhances our spoken language. Fluent speakers naturally incorporate idiomatic expressions, making conversations more engaging and colorful.



Idiom 1:

"We showed the president 20 ideas for new products, but she didn't like any of them - so we had to go back to the drawing board."

- a) ask other people for advice
- b) start again from the beginning
- c) reuse a good idea from the past

1. go back to the drawing board

- b) start again from the beginning

Designers and engineers often draw a picture of a product as the first step in its development. So "going back to the drawing board" means to start again at step 1 of a process.

Idiom 2:

"Our sales estimates were way off the mark. We'd projected sales of \$15M, but the actual numbers were closer to \$9M."

- a) too optimistic
- b) higher than average
- c) very wrong/inaccurate

2. way off the mark

c) very wrong/inaccurate

This idiom comes from the sport of archery, where arrows that do not hit the target are said to be "off the mark." The word "way" means "very" - so "way off the mark" means "very inaccurate."



Idiom 3:

"The text for the article is almost perfect. I just want to tweak one or two sentences."

- a) remove
- b) make small adjustments
- c) make longer

3. tweak

- b) make small adjustments

I don't know the origin of this word, but it can be used as either a noun or a verb - you can say "I want to tweak one or two things" or "I want to make a few tweaks" to talk about minor adjustments.

Idiom 4:

"I need to submit a weekly report on this project, so please keep me in the loop."

- a) informed / updated
- b) working hard
- c) in the office

4. in the loop

- a) informed / updated

You can also say the opposite - "out of the loop" - if you are not being informed or updated about a project or news.



Idiom 5:

"Three people from my department are on vacation, so I've got a lot on my plate at the moment."

- a) I have a lot of responsibilities
- b) I wish I was on vacation, too
- c) I have nothing to do

5. I've got a lot on my plate

- a) I have a lot of responsibilities

If you go to a buffet and you put a lot of food on your plate, then you are obligated to eat it all. So having "a lot on your plate" means you have many tasks or responsibilities.

Idiom 6:

"The rule of thumb is to reinvest no more than 30%, but it's OK if you go over that number occasionally."

- a) minimum amount
- b) strict limit
- c) general practice

6. rule of thumb

- c) general practice

A "rule of thumb" is a general rule or general practice that may have exceptions in some situations. This is your "thumb":

If you use your thumb to measure something, you can get a general idea, but the measurement will not be perfectly accurate. So a general rule with exceptions permitted is called a "rule of thumb."



Idiom 7:

"Bob said I missed the deadline, but I want to set the record straight – I submitted my work on time, but he didn't check his e-mail."

- a) correct a mistake and say the truth
- b) express a different opinion
- c) get permission

7. set the record straight

- a) correct a mistake and say the truth

When there is a misunderstanding or something was falsely reported, you should "set the record straight" – say what is true, so that people have the correct understanding of the situation.

Idiom 8:

"We have until December to prepare these documents, so let's put them on the back burner for now. We have other, more urgent projects."

- a) send them back to their origin
- b) give them low priority
- c) finish them quickly

8. put something on the back burner

- b) give it low priority

This idiom comes from cooking. This picture shows a stove with four burners: If you are cooking multiple things at the same time, you put the less important items, which don't need your attention, on the back burner - and you put the items on which you are actively working on the front burner. So to "put something on the back burner" is to temporarily give it low priority and less attention.



Idiom 9:

"That program never produced any significant results, so the director finally decided to pull the plug."

- a) get personally involved
- b) improve the technology
- c) stop, discontinue

9. pull the plug

- c) stop, discontinue

If you pull (remove) the plug of your television from the source of electricity, the television will stop working. So to "pull the plug" on a project or program means to discontinue it.



Idiom 10:

"Yesterday's meeting lasted four hours... but in a nutshell, we decided to close our office in India and open a branch in China."

- a) in an argument
- b) in the end
- c) in summary

10. in a nutshell

- c) in summary

When you summarize a lot of information in a short phrase or explanation, you can begin the statement with "in a nutshell." This picture shows nuts: The "shell" is the hard exterior of the nut. A nutshell is very small - so when you put a lot of information into a small number of words, you can say "in a nutshell" to express the fact that you are giving a summary.



Idiom 11:

"Laura didn't go to the meeting. Could you send her a summary of the discussion to bring her up to speed?"

- a) help her work faster
- b) give her the most recent information
- c) find out what her perspective is

11. bring her up to speed

- b) give her the most recent information

If someone is "up to speed," it means they are fully informed about the latest information. To "bring" or "get" someone up to speed is to give them the most recent information so that they can be up-to-date on the current situation.



Idiom 12:

"Don't make any changes without talking to Peter. He's the one calling the shots on this project."

- a) communicating with the supervisor
- b) making the important decisions
- c) working very hard

12. calling the shots

- b) making the important decisions

The person who is "calling the shots" is the one who has authority to decide what must be done, and other people must follow his/her instructions.

Choose the best idiom to complete each sentence in the dialogue below

a lot on your plate	calling the shots	rule of thumb
on the back burner	in a nutshell	tweak
bring me up to speed	in the loop	way off the mark
	back to the drawing board	

Diane: I've been away for the past couple weeks – can you
(1)_____ on this project?

Bill: All the specifications are in the shared folder... but (2)_____,
the client wants us to create an e-commerce site.

Diane: That sounds pretty straightforward. How's it going?

Bill: It's taking forever! They keep wanting to (3)_____ the
design, and they never seem satisfied.

Diane: But you must be getting close, right? At least they haven't made you go (4)_____.

Bill: Actually, they did that last month. I had to come up with a whole new design.

Diane: Why are they being so picky? Who's (5)_____ on this project in the client's company?

Bill: I've been working with the marketing director, but the problem is that she's been keeping the CEO (6)_____, and he makes suggestions that are (7)_____. He doesn't know a thing about websites.

Diane: What kinds of things does he want?

Bill: Here's an example – the (8)_____ in web design is to use font size 14 or greater, but he wants the text as small as possible so more can fit on the page.

Diane: Sounds like you've got (9)_____. Anything I can do to help make things easier?

Bill: You've got a way with words – maybe you can talk to them and explain that if this site doesn't get done soon, I'll have to put it (10)_____. We have other clients who need our help, too.

Answers

1. bring me up to speed
2. in a nutshell
3. tweak
4. back to the drawing board
5. calling the shots
6. in the loop
7. way off the mark
8. rule of thumb
9. a lot on your plate
10. on the back burner





Thank you